

THE PROTEIN PLAYBOOK

NUTRITION GUIDE

A RECOV PLAYBOOK

The Protein *Playbook*

Fuel your fitness and build your best body
— the science of protein, made simple and
put on your plate.

YOUR COACH

Daniel Delahunty

POWERED BY

RECOV

WELCOME

Protein is the *building block* of everything.

Proteins are the workhorses of the body — from the structure of your cells to the chemical reactions that power your muscles, they're behind virtually every biological process.

Whether you're an athlete chasing performance, after a balanced diet, or just curious about the science, this guide has you covered. We'll unravel how protein works, how much you actually need, the best sources, the supplements worth your money, how to plan meals — and finish with nine high-protein recipes you can cook tonight. Let's dive in.



Daniel Delahunty

FITNESS COACH

I've spent years helping people use nutrition to build the body and health they want. Protein is where most people are leaving results on the table — so I put everything I know about it in one place.

THE PLAYBOOK AT A GLANCE

From the science all the way to your plate.

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3 breakfasts, 3 lunches, 3 dinners.

A top-down view of various protein sources arranged on a light-colored wooden surface. In the center is a piece of raw red meat. To its left is a bowl of white rice. Above the meat is a whole brown egg and a cracked egg with a bright yellow yolk. To the right of the meat is a bowl of lentils. In the top left is a bowl of brown lentils. In the top right is a bowl of yellow lentils. In the bottom right is a small dish with three pieces of light brown tofu. Several almonds are scattered in the foreground.

CHAPTER 01

Understanding Protein

Proteins are the fundamental building blocks of life — essential to the structure, function and regulation of your body. From the strength of your muscles to the intricate processes inside your cells, they're involved in almost every aspect of your existence.

Proteins are large, complex molecules made of smaller units called amino acids, joined in a specific sequence to form a long chain — a polypeptide. That sequence determines the unique structure and function of each protein.

They provide structure and support, enable chemical reactions, and carry signals between cells. Understanding their role sets the foundation for everything that follows — health, nutrition and fitness.

A top-down view of a white bowl filled with soba (buckwheat) noodles, topped with sliced avocado, red bell peppers, and other vegetables. A hand is visible on the right side of the frame, holding a pair of light-colored wooden chopsticks. The background is a soft, out-of-focus grey.

CHAPTER 02

What Protein Does Inside the Body

Proteins aren't passive — they're dynamic, versatile molecules doing a huge range of essential jobs. Here are four of the biggest.

ENZYMES

Catalyse the chemical reactions behind metabolism and digestion — breaking complex molecules down, building new ones, and regulating metabolic pathways.

TRANSPORT & SIGNALLING

Channels and transporters move ions and nutrients in and out of cells; receptor proteins receive signals and trigger the right cellular response.

STRUCTURAL SUPPORT

Actin and myosin drive muscle movement; keratin strengthens hair and nails. Structural proteins hold your tissues together.

HORMONES & REGULATION

Some proteins are messengers — insulin regulates blood sugar. Others govern DNA replication, gene expression and healthy growth.



CHAPTER 03

Protein Health Benefits

Something that seems so small at a cellular level shows up in big, physical ways across your whole body.

MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

Supplies amino acids for repair and growth after training, preserves muscle during weight loss and ageing, and — with resistance work — builds strength.

WEIGHT MANAGEMENT

Highly satiating, so you feel full and overeat less. Higher intake also lifts thermogenesis and metabolic rate.

BLOOD SUGAR

Paired with carbs, protein slows digestion for a more gradual glucose release — fewer spikes, better control.

BONE HEALTH

Collagen frames your bones; higher protein intake is linked to greater bone density and fewer fractures, especially in older adults.

IMMUNE FUNCTION

Antibodies are proteins that neutralise bacteria and viruses, and protein fuels the production of immune cells.

SKIN, HAIR & NAILS

Supplies the collagen and keratin behind strength and structure, aids wound healing and tissue repair.

Muscle Building With Protein

When you train, your muscles take on microscopic damage — normal and necessary for growth. To repair and come back stronger, they need a steady supply of amino acids from protein. Here's how to make that intake count.

Protein quality

Favour high-quality sources that deliver all the essential amino acids — lean meats, poultry, fish, eggs and dairy. Plant sources like legumes, soy, quinoa and hemp seeds contribute too, especially when you combine them.

Leucine-rich foods

Leucine is the amino acid that switches on muscle protein synthesis. Work in Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, chicken, fish and soy.

Timing

Spread protein evenly across the day, with a quality source in every meal and snack. Protein around your workout is especially useful for stimulating synthesis and recovery.

THE MUSCLE-BUILDING CHECKLIST

- Hit high-quality, complete-protein sources daily.
- Include leucine-rich foods to trigger synthesis.
- Distribute protein across every meal — don't back-load it.
- Use a supplement to top up when whole foods fall short.

CHAPTER 05

Myths & Misconceptions

Protein is talked about constantly — and surrounded by myths. Let's clear up the five biggest.

1 MYTH

High-protein diets damage your kidneys

Not supported by the evidence. Healthy people with normal kidney function can safely eat high-protein diets. (Those with existing kidney disease should follow their doctor's advice.)

2 MYTH

More protein = more muscle

There's a ceiling on how much protein the body uses for muscle synthesis. Eating beyond your needs doesn't add extra growth.

3 MYTH

Plant proteins are inferior

Many plant sources provide all the essential amino acids. A varied diet of legumes, grains, nuts and seeds delivers ample high-quality protein.

4
MYTH

Supplements are essential

Convenient, yes — essential, no. A balanced diet of protein-rich whole foods covers most people. Supplements top up; they don't replace food.

5
MYTH

Protein causes weight gain

Protein has a higher thermic effect than carbs or fat — your body burns more digesting it — and its satiating effect helps cut overall intake.

CHAPTER 06

How Much Protein Do You Need



Your needs depend on age, sex, activity and goals. Here's a reliable starting framework, by daily grams per kilogram of body weight.

0.8g

SEDENTARY / KG

1.2–1.6g

ACTIVE / KG

1.6–2.2g

ATHLETES / KG

WORKED EXAMPLE

- A 70 kg (154 lb) strength trainer lands at roughly **112–154g of protein per day** .
- Distribute it across the day rather than one big hit, to maximise muscle protein synthesis.



CHAPTER 07

The Best Protein Sources

Whether you eat animal or plant-based, here's how the most popular sources stack up — protein per 100g.

Animal-based

WHEY PROTEIN

76g

per 100g

CHICKEN

31g

per 100g

TURKEY

29g

per 100g

TUNA

26g

per 100g

BEEF

26g

per 100g

SALMON

22g

per 100g

PRAWNS

20g

per 100g

CHEESE

20g

per 100g

PORK

19g

per 100g

EGGS

13g

per 100g

GREEK YOGHURT

10g

per 100g

COW'S MILK

3g

per 100g

Plant-based

PEANUT BUTTER

25g
per 100g

ALMONDS

21g
per 100g

CHICKPEAS

19g
per 100g

CASHEWS

18g
per 100g

OATS

17g
per 100g

QUINOA

14g
per 100g

EDAMAME

11g
per 100g

LENTILS

9g
per 100g

TOFU

8g
per 100g

BROCCOLI

3g
per 100g

BROWN RICE

3g
per 100g

AVOCADO

2g
per 100g

Values are protein grams per 100g of food.

CHAPTER 08

Protein Supplements 101

Protein powders are a convenient, easily digestible way to top up — especially post-workout or when whole foods are hard to fit in. Here's how the main types compare.

1

Whey

Derived from milk during cheese-making (concentrate or isolate). Fast-digesting and popular for muscle growth and recovery — for those without dairy issues.

2

Casein

Also from milk, but forms a gel in the stomach for slow, sustained amino-acid release. Great before bed or long gaps without food.

3

Soy

A complete plant protein with all essential amino acids. Suits vegetarians, vegans and the lactose-intolerant; may support heart and hormonal health.

4

Pea

From yellow split peas — easily digestible, low-allergen, well balanced (a little low in methionine). Combine with other plant proteins for a fuller profile.

5

Rice

From brown rice — hypoallergenic and vegan-friendly. Not complete alone, so pair with other plant sources for a balanced amino profile.

6

Hemp

A complete plant protein from hemp seeds, with bonus omega-3s and fibre. Supports muscle growth and recovery with extra nutritional upside.



CHAPTER 09

Protein & Meal Planning

No scales needed. Use your hand to build a balanced, protein-forward plate every time.

1

Protein

1-2 palms per plate

2

Carbs

1-2 cupped hands per plate

3

Fats

1-2 thumbs per plate

4

Vegetables

1-2 fists per plate

Build each meal in that order and your protein takes care of itself — no tracking app required.



CHAPTER 10

9 High-Protein Recipes

Three breakfasts, three lunches, three dinners — each one serving, each macro-counted.

Breakfast

3 RECIPES



Overnight Strawberry Cheesecake

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN NO COOK

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp chia seeds
- 1¾ cup plain nonfat Greek yogurt
- 2½ tbsp low-fat cream cheese
- ¾ cup vanilla almond milk
- ¾ cup frozen unsweetened strawberries

METHOD

1. Whisk all ingredients except strawberries until combined.
2. Mix in half the chopped strawberries (save the rest).
3. Cover and refrigerate overnight.
4. Top with remaining strawberries in the morning.

509

CALORIES

52g

PROTEIN

39g

CARBS

17g

FAT



Mexican Omelette with Black Beans

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 10 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs + 1 cup egg whites
- 2 tbsp nutritional yeast
- 1 cup cubed avocado
- 1 oz red onion
- ¼ green + ¼ red bell pepper
- ¼ cup black beans
- Cooking spray

METHOD

1. Mix egg whites, whole eggs, nutritional yeast, salt and pepper.
2. Cook the egg mixture in a sprayed nonstick pan over low heat.
3. Transfer the cooked omelette to a plate.
4. Sauté peppers, onion and beans until soft.
5. Spoon onto one side, fold into a half-moon, top with avocado.

543

CALORIES

54g

PROTEIN

44g

CARBS

16g

FAT



Vegan Tofu Golden Milk Bowl

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN NO COOK

INGREDIENTS

- 1 scoop golden milk blend
- ½ banana
- ⅔ cup firm tofu
- 1 cup almond milk
- ⅔ cup rolled oats
- ½ cup raspberries
- 1 tbsp hemp seeds
- Sweetener to taste

METHOD

1. Blend everything except raspberries and hemp seeds until smooth.
2. Pour into a bowl; top with raspberries and hemp seeds.
3. Optional: add ginger, turmeric, cinnamon and black pepper for a golden twist.

517

CALORIES

28g

PROTEIN

68g

CARBS

19g

FAT

Lunch

3 RECIPES



Vegan Mushroom & Zucchini Stew

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 30 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup beef-free crumble
- 2 zucchini, ribboned
- 1 cup mushrooms
- 1 cup spinach
- 1 cup diced tomatoes
- 1 cup onion, 3 cloves garlic
- 3 tbsp vegan mozzarella
- Basil, oregano, olive oil

METHOD

1. Sauté onion and garlic until soft.
2. Add crumble, tomatoes, mushrooms, spinach and herbs; cook till tender.
3. Layer half in a dish, add zucchini ribbons, then the rest; top with mozzarella.
4. Bake covered 20 min, then uncovered 10 min till melted.

542

CALORIES

37g

PROTEIN

56g

CARBS

22g

FAT



Paleo Stuffed Sweet Potato & Turkey

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 15 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 6.5 oz lean ground turkey
- 1 large sweet potato
- 2 cups spinach
- ¼ cup red bell pepper
- 2 slices cooked bacon
- 2 tsp coconut oil
- ⅓ tsp cinnamon

METHOD

1. Crisp the diced bacon; set aside. Microwave the pierced sweet potato ~5 min.
2. Sauté bell pepper in coconut oil, add turkey and cook through, stir in spinach.
3. Slice the potato open, sprinkle cinnamon, mash the inside.
4. Stuff with the turkey filling and top with bacon.

538

CALORIES

54g

PROTEIN

43g

CARBS

18g

FAT



Pan Steak with Baby Potatoes

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 20 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 5.3 oz lean beef flank steak
- 6.7 oz baby new potatoes
- 0.33 lb broccoli
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 clove garlic
- 1/3 tsp dried thyme

METHOD

1. Boil potatoes ~12 min until half-tender; drain.
2. On an oiled tray, toss potatoes and broccoli with oil, garlic, thyme, salt and pepper.
3. Season the steak and add to the tray.
4. Broil 4-5 min until the steak is browned to your liking. Serve.

538

CALORIES

40g

PROTEIN

43g

CARBS

21g

FAT

Dinner

3 RECIPES



Cauliflower Rice with Egg & Asparagus

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 10 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup riced cauliflower
- ¼ cup cooked white rice
- ½ cup seitan strips
- 2 eggs
- ½ cup asparagus, ½ cup red pepper
- ½ cup carrots, green onion, garlic
- Turmeric, olive oil, sesame seeds

METHOD

1. Chop the veg and seitan small; cook the cauliflower rice with turmeric, salt and pepper, then mix with the white rice.
2. Heat oil and garlic in a large pan; add veg and seitan, cook till tender.
3. Push aside, scramble the eggs in the space, then combine.
4. Plate and garnish with sesame seeds.

528

CALORIES

51g

PROTEIN

40g

CARBS

19g

FAT



Tuna Pasta Salad with Cherry Tomatoes

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 10 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can tuna in water
- 2 oz dry white pasta
- ½ cup cherry tomatoes, halved
- 1 carrot, thinly sliced
- 2 tbsp parsley
- 1 tbsp olive oil, 2 tbsp lemon juice

METHOD

1. Cook the pasta, cool under cold water and drain.
2. Combine pasta with tuna, tomatoes, carrot and parsley.
3. Add olive oil, lemon juice, salt and pepper; toss to coat. Serve.

525

CALORIES

41g

PROTEIN

55g

CARBS

16g

FAT



Chicken Fajita Wrap with Peppers

1 SERVING PREP 5 MIN COOK 10 MIN

INGREDIENTS

- 4 oz chicken breast
- 2 tsp fajita seasoning
- Red, yellow & green bell peppers
- ½ cup onion, 1 clove garlic
- ¼ cup avocado
- 1 sprouted-grain tortilla
- Coriander, oil, salt & pepper

METHOD

1. Chop the veg and slice the chicken into strips.
2. In an Instant Pot, combine oil, garlic, onion, peppers, chicken and seasoning; cook on high pressure 6 min.
3. Release pressure, stir through coriander.
4. Spread avocado on the tortilla, add the filling, roll and serve.

533

CALORIES

46g

PROTEIN

58g

CARBS

15g

FAT

RECOVER FASTER

Protein you can actually absorb

You've seen how much protein matters — and that what you can absorb is what counts. Recov delivers all 20 amino acids in a pre-digested form your body puts to work in minutes: the fastest way to top up around training, with none of the bloat.



Recov

The science-led recovery formula

- All 20 amino acids — a complete profile
- Pre-digested & absorbed in ~15–20 minutes
- Ideal post-workout and before bed
- No bloat — built by a scientist, formulation first

Fuel it properly. Recover faster.

Eat the protein, then make sure your body can use it. Start your first bottle of Recov.

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Pair Recov with the playbook. If your recovery doesn't feel sharper, we'll make it right — just reach out.

Want Daniel to build your nutrition plan? He coaches a small number of clients each intake
— details inside your Recov welcome email.



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with Daniel Delahunty

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